integer dba_open(string filename, string mode, string type, ...)

Use dba_open to establish a link to a dbm-style database. A positive integer will be returned if the open is successful, FALSE if it fails. The filename argument is simply the path to a database. The mode argument can be one of four characters that control input and output of data. Table 2 lists the four modes.

Table 2. DBA open modes

Mode	Description
c	If the database does not exist, it will be created. Reads and writes may be performed.
n	If the database does not exist, it will be created. If it does exist, all records will be deleted. Reads and writes may be performed.
r	Only reads may be performed.
w	Reads and writes may be performed. If the file does not exist, an error occurs.

The type argument chooses the underlying database engine. Table 3 describes the four types. You may also supply any number of optional arguments that will be passed directly to the underlying engine.

Table 3. DBA database engine codes

Code	Description
dbm	This code represents the original style of DBM database as developed at Berkeley.
ndbm	This code stands for a newer version of the DBM standard with less restrictions than dbm.
gdbm	The GNU Database Manager is the result of project by GNU. You can download gdbm from the GNU FTP server < ftp://ftp.gnu.org/gnu/gdbm>.
db2	This code stands for a database package developed by Sleepycat software that is based on the original Berkeley source code. In fact, the founders wrote the original DBM at Berkeley. You can get more information and download software at their Web site: .
cdb	CDB is a package for creating constant databases—that is, databases that are read created and read from only. This offers a performance advantage with the tradeoff being that none of the writing functions work. To download the sofware, visit < ftp://koobera.math.uic.edu/www/cdb.html >.

When your script finishes executing, the database link will close automatically. You may choose to close it sooner with dba_close, and this may save some small amount of memory. Contrast this function to dba_popen, which attempts to reuse links.